

While strategically important Virginia seceded on April 17, along with Arkansas, North Carolina, and Tennessee in the following month, Maryland remained with the Union. Moreover, even in Virginia, the poorest and mostly nonenslaving farmers of the state's western counties held out for the Union cause—leading eventually to the founding of the state of West Virginia.

Virginia and Tennessee made the Confederacy a viable nation, but there still remained the prize of Kentucky, with its large population and a northern border on the Ohio River that could serve as a defensive barrier against Union invasion. Slavery had a weaker status in the Bluegrass state than in the Old Dominion, and the state did not immediately secede in response to Lincoln's call for many volunteers. Instead, Kentucky acted in the tradition of Henry Clay, the great sectional compromiser, and hoped to adopt a neutral stance toward both the U.S. and Confederate governments.

The fate of Missouri, the origin of so many of the troubles in "Bleeding Kansas" also hung in the balance, although the state did not have the strategic significance of Kentucky.